

The Florentine Diamond [C1]

Non è solo la storia di un preziosissimo gioiello di cui si erano perse le tracce da oltre cent'anni, ma è anche quella di una famiglia, gli Asburgo, tra guerre, fughe e segreti mantenuti per generazioni. Una trama degna di un film.



In 1918, as World War One was ending, Charles I — the emperor of Austria-Hungary and a member of the Habsburg dynasty — sensed the end of the empire. Charles, a nephew of Franz Ferdinand, whose assassination had incited the conflagration, recognized [mounting threats](#) from Bolsheviks and anarchists. To [safeguard](#) jewels that the [ruling](#) Habsburgs had owned for centuries, he had them transported to Switzerland. One gem in the collection was a particular [prize](#), a 137-carat diamond admired not only for its pear shape and yellow [hue](#) but also for its illustrious history. Before the Habsburgs, it had been owned by the Medici family, the rulers of Florence, Italy. The diamond's [allure](#) only grew when, soon after Charles and his family left Vienna for exile in Switzerland, it was thought to have disappeared. For decades, it was rumoured to have been stolen or perhaps recut. Several films and novels have [anchored](#) their plot on its disappearance. But the real story of what happened to the diamond, now told for the first time by the descendants of Charles I, is that it never really went missing. It's been in a bank [vault](#) in Canada since the family [fled](#) there [in the midst of](#) World War Two, according to three Habsburg [relatives](#) who last month invited The New York Times to inspect the diamond and other jewels. Karl von Habsburg-Lothringen, sixty-four, a grandson of Charles I, said in an interview that the secret had been kept [out of](#) respect for Charles' wife, the Empress Zita. She told only two people — her sons Robert and Rodolphe — about the diamond's location, he said, and asked that, as a security precaution, it be kept [undisclosed](#) for one hundred years after Charles' death in 1922. Before they died, the brothers passed the information to their own sons, according to the family. In the [ensuing](#) years, if anyone asked about the diamond, the family said it declined to respond [out of](#) a desire to guard the jewel. Large and Famous Diamonds. "The less people know about it, the bigger the security," said von Habsburg-Lothringen. He said he had only recently learned of the existence of the jewels from his two cousins — Robert's son, Lorenz von Habsburg-Lothringen, seventy, and Rodolphe's son, Simeon von Habsburg-Lothringen, sixty-seven. "Over the years, I am sure all of us has been asked at one time or another" about the diamond," Karl von Habsburg-Lothringen said. "For me, I was not even [aware](#) of the existence of the diamond until recently, so it was easy to answer those questions honestly." But now, with the [vow fulfilled](#), the family wants to display the Florentine Diamond and other jewels in Canada to thank the country for [taking in](#) the Empress and her children. On a recent rainy afternoon, the family gathered at the bank in Canada where the jewels have long resided in a [vault](#). Standing with his two cousins around a table, von Habsburg-Lothringen slowly opened the [battered](#) suitcase put before them. [Gingerly](#), he removed the yellowed paper in which each jewel was [wrapped](#), eventually coming to the diamond itself, still [glittering](#) and [arresting](#). Christoph Köchert of A.E. Köchert jewelers, once Austria's imperial court jewelers, examined the diamond and [attested to](#) its authenticity. "Its [cut pattern](#) corresponds almost exactly to representations in historical sources," he said in a statement. Citing additional factors, he added, "All of this gives me certainty that this is the genuine, historical Florentine Diamond." Culture

The Koh-i-Noor: The World's Most Dangerous Diamond Il Koh-i-Noor è il diamante più ambito e maledetto al mondo. Per secoli vari imperi hanno lottato per cercare di impossessarsi di questa straordinaria gemma. Il suo incorporamento ai gioielli della corona britannica è avvolto in una sanguinosa leggenda. Conor Gleeson , Sarah Davison The collection includes a number of other items of jewelry, including a diamond-encrusted [Order of the Golden Fleece](#), the house order of the Habsburg family. With the extinction of the male Medici line, the Florentine Diamond became the property of the House of Habsburg-Lorraine, established in 1736 through the marriage of Francis Stephen and Archduchess Maria Theresa of Austria, the parents of Marie Antoinette. The diamond adorned Francis Stephen's crown during his coronation as Holy Roman Emperor in 1745. The house produced every Holy Roman Emperor from 1440 to 1806, with the exception of the brief Wittelsbach interregnum of 1742 to 1745. And the family provided emperors of Austria from 1804 to 1918. A replica of the Florentine Diamond imitating its yellow colour. Emperor Charles I of Austria marrying Princess Zita of Bourbon-Parma in 1911. "The Habsburgs are the greatest dynasty of modern history — the history of Central Europe revolves around them," said Richard Bassett, an [associate fellow](#) of Christ's College, Cambridge, who has written a book on the Habsburgs and whom the family commissioned to write a report on the diamond's history. After Charles I died from pneumonia in Madeira, Portugal, where the family had moved from Switzerland, Empress Zita and her children relocated to Spain and then to Belgium in 1929. As [tensions built](#) across Europe, Zita and her eldest son, Crown Prince Otto, vigorously opposed the growing Nazi threat, and Otto offered his services to the increasingly fragile Austrian First Republic as it struggled to remain independent of the Third Reich. When the Nazis annexed Austria in 1938, an event known as the Anschluss, Otto was declared an enemy of the state. Concerned that Germany was about to invade Belgium, Zita [fled](#) with her eight children, ultimately arriving in the United States in 1940, according to the family. The empress, family members said, carried the jewels with her in a small [cardboard](#) suitcase. Finally, with American help, the family traveled to Canada and [settled](#) in a modest house in the province of Quebec. "My grandmother felt very [safe](#) — she could breathe finally," von Habsburg-Lothringen said. "I assume that, at that stage, the little suitcase went into a bank [safe](#), and that was it. And in that bank [safe](#), it just stayed." In 1953, Zita returned to Europe and left the jewels in the care of the Quebec bank. She died in Switzerland in 1989 at ninety-six. "I think she wanted to make sure that it was not in her lifetime," von Habsburg-Lothringen said of the jewels' resurfacing. "I have the feeling she was very glad that some important objects of the family are something that she had saved. That was historically very important for her, because she was somebody who was thinking very much in historic terms." The rumored disappearance of the Florentine Diamond has long [spawned](#) speculation. "One theory holds that the Habsburgs, much like the Romanovs following the Russian Revolution, sold the diamond and other possessions for cash," an article in Artnet (a website focused on the art market) offered last year, "after which it was cut up

and sold to unknown buyers.” Archduchess Maria Maddalena of Austria (1589-1631) wears the diamond as a head dress. “A more hopeful but less likely hypothesis,” the article went on, “holds that the Florentine Diamond wasn’t sold at all, but given to a Habsburg servant who took it to South America, and that it’s still out there — somewhere.” Some in the gemology world suspected that the diamond had been recut to [conceal](#) its identity — similar to what is feared to have happened to the jewels recently stolen from the Louvre. When a yellow diamond, roughly half the size of the Florentine, [surfaced](#) at [auction](#) in 1981, many [jumped to the conclusion](#) that it had most likely come from the missing gem. Bassett’s report says the jewels that Charles I took with him were listed in a separate inventory from the state crown jewels of the Habsburg monarchy. He said this position — that items taken by the family were the private property of the Habsburg-Lorraine house — was confirmed by a legal advocate for the imperial family in 1921, when the Austrian government put pressure on the Swiss government for their return. While the First Austrian Republic enacted legislation in 1919 that expropriated the Habsburg family’s private property in Austria, Bassett said it did not apply to the jewels because by that time they were outside Austria. The family says it wants to display the diamond at a Canadian museum in the next few years. But there is no plan to sell the diamond, it said, and the family declined to speculate on the jewel’s monetary value. “It’s an extraordinary achievement to have managed to preserve it for one hundred years actually incognito,” Bassett said. “It’s an astonishing tribute to the Empress Zita’s practical determination. And she was a very practical woman.” Published in The New York Times on 6 November 2025. Reprinted with permission.

Glossary

- **Order of the Golden Fleece** = Ordine del Toson d'Oro
- **ruling** = al potere, regnanti
- **glittering** = scintillante, brillante
- **attested to** = attestare, certificare
- **settled** = stabilirsi
- **safe** = cassaforte
- **surfaced** = emergere, apparire
- **mounting threats** = crescenti minacce
- **relatives** = parenti
- **battered** = malconcia
- **tensions built** = aumentare le tensioni
- **hue** = sfumatura
- **allure** = fascino
- **in the midst of** = nel mezzo di
- **aware** = consapevole
- **taking in** = accogliere, dare rifugio
- **arresting** = impressionante
- **associate fellow** = membro associato
- **cardboard** = cartone
- **prize** = pezzo pregiato
- **vault** = caveau, camera blindata
- **vow** = promessa
- **fled** = fuggire
- **ensuing** = successivi
- **Gingerly** = delicatamente
- **wrapped** = avvolgere
- **conceal** = nascondere
- **spawned** = generare
- **auction** = asta
- **jumped to the conclusion** = giungere alla conclusione
- **anchored** = basare
- **out of** = in segno di
- **undisclosed** = non rivelato, riservato
- **fulfilled** = compiere
- **cut pattern** = schema di taglio